

# TechSoup Website Audit

Rhys Williams



Auditor: Rhys Williams

Website: [TechSoup](https://techsoup.org)

Contact: [rhwi3413@colorado.edu](mailto:rhwi3413@colorado.edu)

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Institution: University of Colorado Boulder

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## About the auditor

Rhys Williams is an aspiring UX Designer at the University of Colorado Boulder, studying Creative Technology and Design and minoring in Data Science. This audit was conducted with months of evaluation focusing on the heuristics, content, and visual design of the site.

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## What is a UX Audit?

A UX audit is an evaluation of a website's usability, accessibility, content, visual design, and navigation. It identifies where users may experience confusion while trying to complete important tasks.



For TechSoup, this audit helps reveal what parts of the site are already working well and what areas may prevent users from easily finding services, understanding membership steps, or completing actions. By addressing these findings, TechSoup can make the site clearer, easier to navigate, and more accessible for nonprofit users.



## Audit Objective

TechSoup is a nonprofit organization that provides technology products and services to other organizations at discounted rates. This website is the primary method to access these resources. This audit aims to identify usability improvements to make it easier for nonprofit organizations to request technology.

## Business Context

The TechSoup website is used as a method for nonprofit organizations to access affordable technology. Their site is built around trustworthy and informative content, while prioritizing navigation to hardware access.

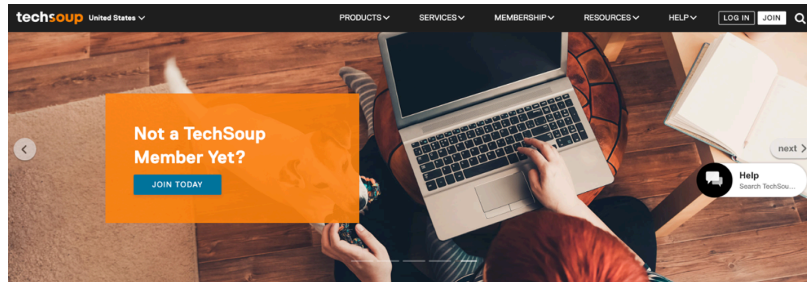
Goal: Provide affordable or donated technology to other nonprofits

Audience: Nonprofit organizations

Purpose: Allowing easy, low-friction access to technology

# Scope

This audit focused on the navigation and service discovery of TechSoup's website. These are crucial for site flow as users need an efficient way to receive support for tech products. This process is the foundation of every interaction that will occur when a user is looking for a service. Additionally, any friction for first-time users can result in them delaying or not getting services.



## Is Your Nonprofit a TechSoup Member Yet?

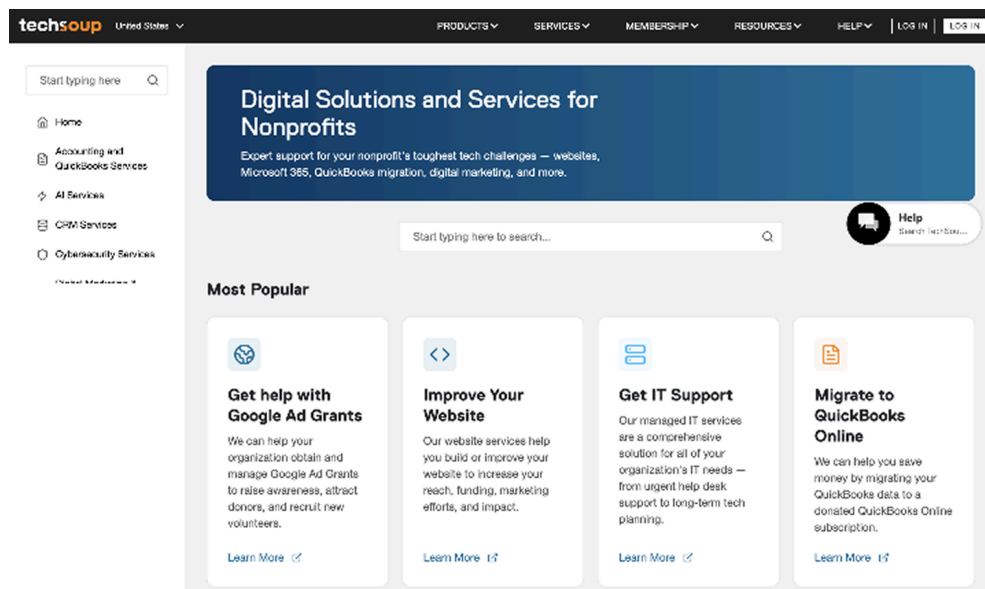
Join the world's leading technology resource for nonprofits by a nonprofit.

**Save on Technology**  
Access nonprofit offers from Microsoft, Adobe, Dell, Intuit, and much more.

**Fast Approval**  
Easy online nonprofit verification gets your organization approved quickly to use our offers.

**Nonprofit Community Support**  
Join and learn from thousands of other digital changemakers working in communities around the world.

[JOIN TECHSOUP](#)  
Zero-cost memberships available.



# Persona-Driven Insights

This persona is trying to navigate to the technology for non-profits page and to scroll through their options. The persona is constrained by the website's lack of guidance and loading time. This means that the experience overall is confusing to navigate and could be simplified further.



**AGE** 24  
**JOB TITLE** Librarian  
**LOCATION** Boulder, CO

## John Nathanson

### ABOUT

John is a college graduate who is beginning to work in a nonprofit organization. He is looking for tech services that are in budget for his organization.

#### GOALS

- Easily access technology
- Find discounts

#### NEEDS

- Simplification
- Direct navigation from the homepage

#### SKILLS

|                       |                        |
|-----------------------|------------------------|
| Tech knowledge        | <div><div></div></div> |
| Nonprofit familiarity | <div><div></div></div> |
| Document organization | <div><div></div></div> |
| Communication         | <div><div></div></div> |

#### PAIN POINTS

- Loading time
- Lacks guidance

# Visual Design Evaluation

Visual design evaluation examines the hierarchy and branding across the site. The design is clear and mission-focused, but its biggest bias is from assumption framing. The homepage prioritizes nonprofit users, which makes sense given it's meant for them, but can also lead to less site traffic. It would be important to introduce context to the headers and not assume the visitors know about any preexisting information. Additionally, considering other audiences, like donors or volunteers, would be beneficial for site traffic.

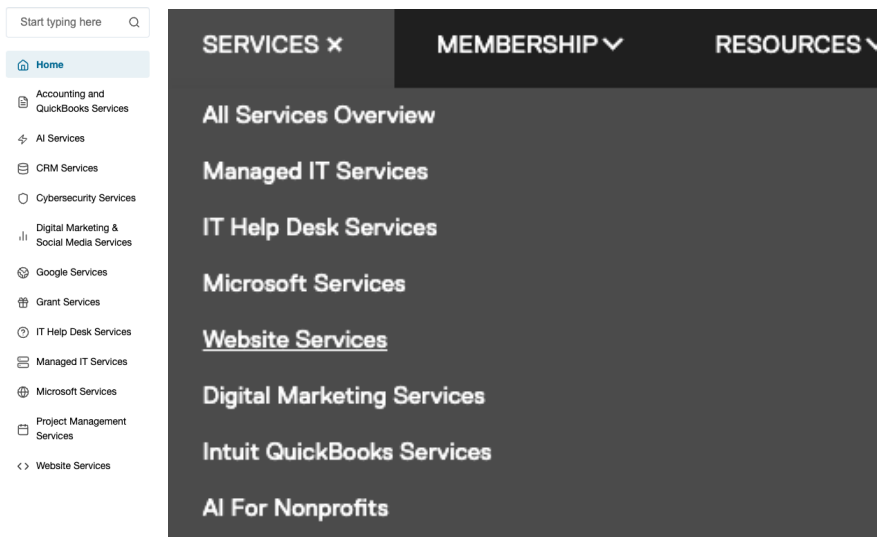
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## FINDING 1 - LOW PRIORITY

### Visual inconsistency between page types

#### EVIDENCE

The service pages display a light-mode navigation bar while the homepage and other pages use a dark-mode nav. This breaks visual consistency and can make the experience feel less polished.



#### RECOMMENDATION

Keep either light mode or dark mode across all pages, or give the user an option to toggle to their preference.

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## FINDING 2 - MEDIUM PRIORITY

### CTA buttons lack visual emphasis

#### EVIDENCE

On the homepage, orange CTA buttons blend in with surrounding elements and colors, making them not stand out as much as they should for a primary call to action. These buttons also fail Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG), lowering viewership from those with sight impairment.



#### RECOMMENDATION

Darken the orange or change it to a different color so the CTA buttons draw more attention and stand out clearly from surrounding content.

# Content Evaluation

A content evaluation examines the words and labels on the site. The buttons and navigation are easy to understand. However, the biggest weakness is the lack of clarity in the mission statement and the initial navigation when entering the site. This creates friction early on and can lead the user to become frustrated. To fix this, the mission statement should be the first thing the user sees, followed by directions on where to go next.

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## FINDING 1 - MEDIUM PRIORITY

Service summaries are too long and cause unnecessary scrolling

### EVIDENCE

Content summaries on certain services are too bulky, adding a lot of unnecessary scrolling for the user.



### RECOMMENDATION

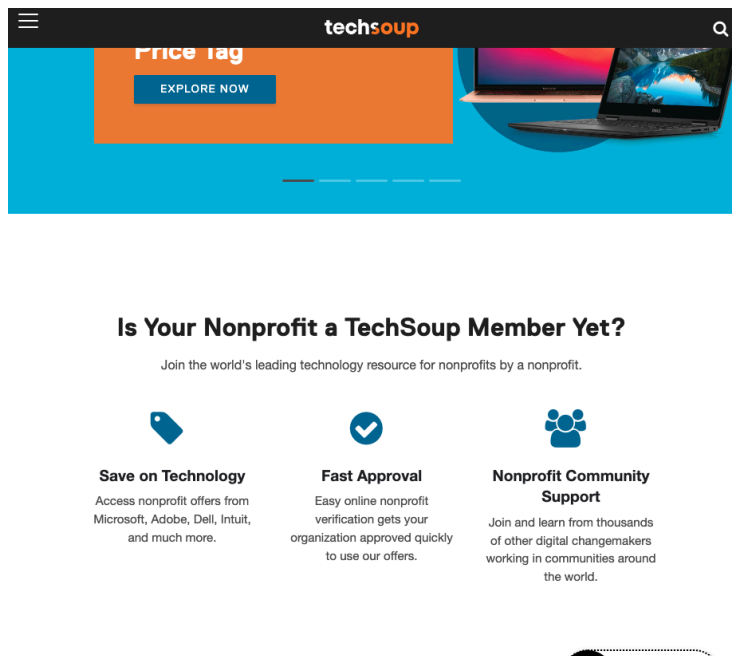
Summarize each service more concisely, especially when the tab shrinks horizontally. On mobile, use single-sentence summaries with an option to expand.

## FINDING 2 - LOW PRIORITY

The site assumes the visitor is a nonprofit seeking technology

### EVIDENCE

The homepage's main CTAs assume visitors are there for nonprofit organizations, which can exclude or confuse audiences that are there for other reasons, as seen in the homepage messaging and membership prompts.



### RECOMMENDATION

Tell users directly that this site is for nonprofit organizations, instead of asking them or offering entry points for other types of visitors.

# Heuristic Evaluation

A heuristic evaluation is a review method using an established set of usability principles called heuristics to find design problems. This method lets a designer identify friction on the site by checking against known patterns of what makes interfaces easy or hard to use.

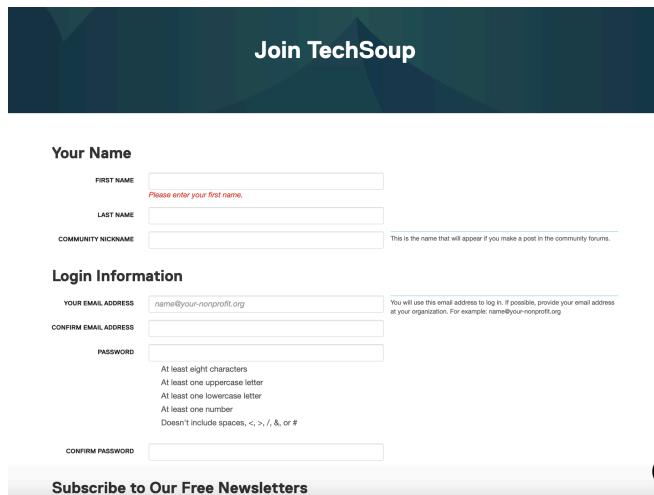
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## FINDING 1 - MEDIUM PRIORITY

Membership validation page gives users friction early in the flow

### EVIDENCE

The membership verification process requires nonprofit validation before users understand what services are available. This violates the User Control and Freedom heuristic, stating users should be able to explore and understand a product before being asked to commit or provide information.



The screenshot shows a 'Join TechSoup' form. It is divided into two main sections: 'Your Name' and 'Login Information'. The 'Your Name' section includes fields for 'FIRST NAME', 'LAST NAME', and 'COMMUNITY NICKNAME'. The 'FIRST NAME' field has a red error message: 'Please enter your first name.' The 'Login Information' section includes fields for 'YOUR EMAIL ADDRESS', 'CONFIRM EMAIL ADDRESS', and 'PASSWORD'. The 'YOUR EMAIL ADDRESS' field contains the text 'name@your-nonprofit.org'. To the right of this field is a note: 'You will use this email address to log in. If possible, provide your email address at your organization. For example: name@your-nonprofit.org'. Below the 'PASSWORD' field are four lines of requirements: 'At least eight characters', 'At least one uppercase letter', 'At least one lowercase letter', and 'At least one number'. Below these is a note: 'Doesn't include spaces, <, >, /, &, or #'. At the bottom of the form is a 'CONFIRM PASSWORD' field and a button labeled 'Subscribe to Our Free Newsletters'.

### RECOMMENDATION

Give users a clear preview of available services before asking them to validate membership. Move the verification step to after the user has decided they want to proceed.

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## FINDING 2 - LOW PRIORITY

### No known shortcuts for experienced users

#### EVIDENCE

Navigation relies entirely on browsing through categories and filters, with no keyboard shortcut options for returning users. This violates the Flexibility and Efficiency of Use heuristic, which states that shortcuts should be available for experienced users so they can complete tasks faster without going through the full browsing flow every time.

#### RECOMMENDATION

Add a shortcut or last visited section for returning users who already know what they want

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## FINDING 3 - LOW PRIORITY

### Inconsistent CTA labeling

#### EVIDENCE

The navigation bar uses 'JOIN' while the homepage body uses 'JOIN TECHSOUP' for the same action. This violates the Consistency and Standards heuristic, which states users should not have to wonder whether different words or labels mean the same thing.



#### RECOMMENDATION

Choose either 'JOIN' or 'JOIN TECHSOUP'.

# Accessibility Evaluation

An accessibility evaluation tests whether the site can be used by people with visual, motor, or cognitive disabilities, measured against WCAG standards. These failures affect real users and can bring both ethical and legal risk for the organization.

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## FINDING 1 - HIGH PRIORITY

Low color contrast on CTA buttons

### EVIDENCE

Light orange buttons with white text fail WCAG AA contrast requirements, which set a minimum ratio of 4.5:1 for normal text. This makes the primary action buttons difficult to read for users with low vision or color blindness.



### RECOMMENDATION

Increase contrast by darkening the orange color or switching to a different color that meets the WCAG AA minimum ratio of 4.5:1.

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## FINDING 2 - MEDIUM PRIORITY

Missing 'Skip to Content' functionality

### EVIDENCE

There is no skip link available on any page. Keyboard users must tab repeatedly through every navigation element before reaching the main content. WCAG 2.4.1 requires a mechanism to bypass repeated blocks of content.

### RECOMMENDATION

Add a 'Skip to Content' link as the first focusable element on every page so keyboard users can bypass the navigation entirely.

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### FINDING 3 - HIGH PRIORITY

#### Keyboard navigation barrier on the All Services page

##### EVIDENCE

The 'Learn More' link on the All Services page cannot be activated without a mouse. Keyboard-only users have no way to access it. This violates WCAG 2.1.1, which requires all functionality to be operable through a keyboard interface.

##### RECOMMENDATION

Ensure the link can be accessed through tabbing to it.

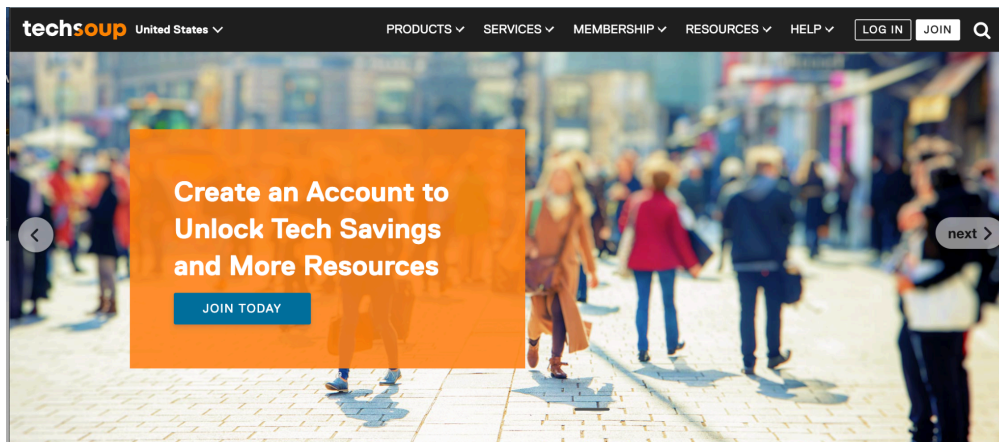
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### FINDING 4 - LOW PRIORITY

#### Keyboard navigation barrier on the homepage carousel

##### EVIDENCE

The left and right carousel arrows at the top of the homepage cannot be accessed without a mouse. This violates WCAG 2.1.1, which requires all functionality to be operable through a keyboard interface.



##### RECOMMENDATION

Add keyboard support so users can navigate the carousel using arrow keys or Tab without needing a mouse.

# User Journey Evaluation

The main usability issues in this flow consist of a lack of confirmation when submitting information and navigating to the next page, and too much content that appears on the service selection screen. I would condense the service selection screen initially by asking users a few simple questions to automatically filter out the services they are not looking for. If I had the chance to test with real users, I would want a way for them to sign up for a certain service on a shorter, more informationally condensed registration screen.

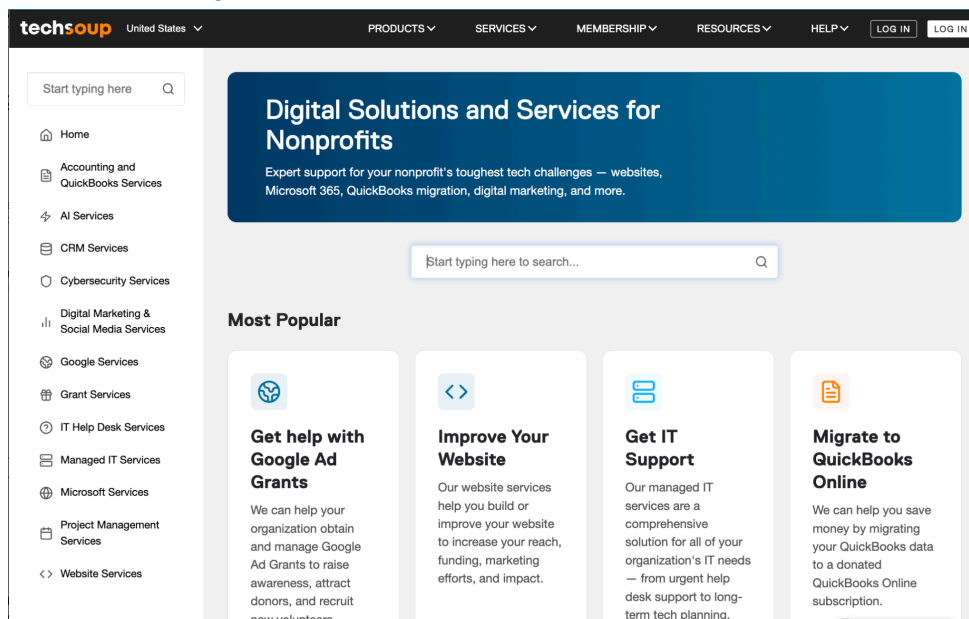
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## FINDING 1 - MEDIUM PRIORITY

### Overwhelming service selection screen

#### EVIDENCE

The user choosing what service to use in the beginning gets overwhelming and causes friction from not knowing what to choose.



#### RECOMMENDATION

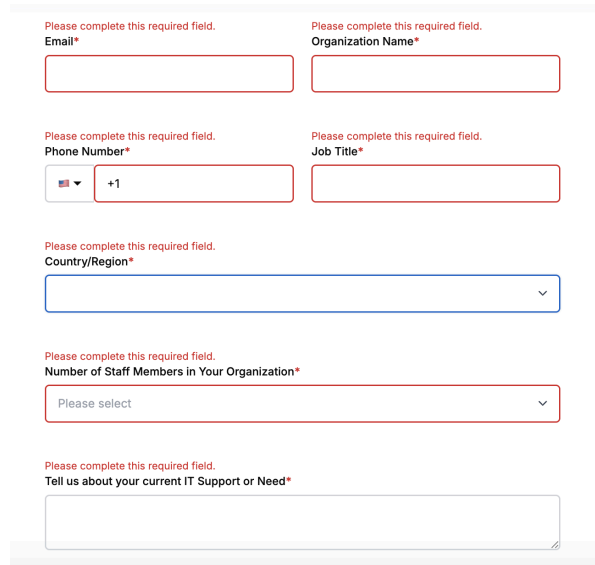
While there are basic filters to select what product you want, having a quick onboarding process where the user goes more in-depth into what they are looking for would help the user receive a product more suited to their needs.

## FINDING 2 - LOW PRIORITY

### Lack of positive feedback in input fields

#### EVIDENCE

The system has negative feedback when submitting blank information, but does not have positive feedback that indicates if something is filled out or completed when signing up. This can cause the user to feel uncertain whether they completed their task or not.



The screenshot shows a registration form with the following fields and associated error messages (all in red text):

- Email\***: "Please complete this required field."
- Organization Name\***: "Please complete this required field."
- Phone Number\***: "Please complete this required field." (The field contains a dropdown for country codes with "+1" selected).
- Job Title\***: "Please complete this required field."
- Country/Region\***: "Please complete this required field." (This is a dropdown menu).
- Number of Staff Members in Your Organization\***: "Please complete this required field." (This is a dropdown menu with "Please select" as the current selection).
- Tell us about your current IT Support or Need\***: "Please complete this required field." (This is a text area).

#### RECOMMENDATION

We would recommend adding a green outline with a checkmark around the input field. This allows the user to visually tell when they are completed with a task, instead of having to check by clicking submit.

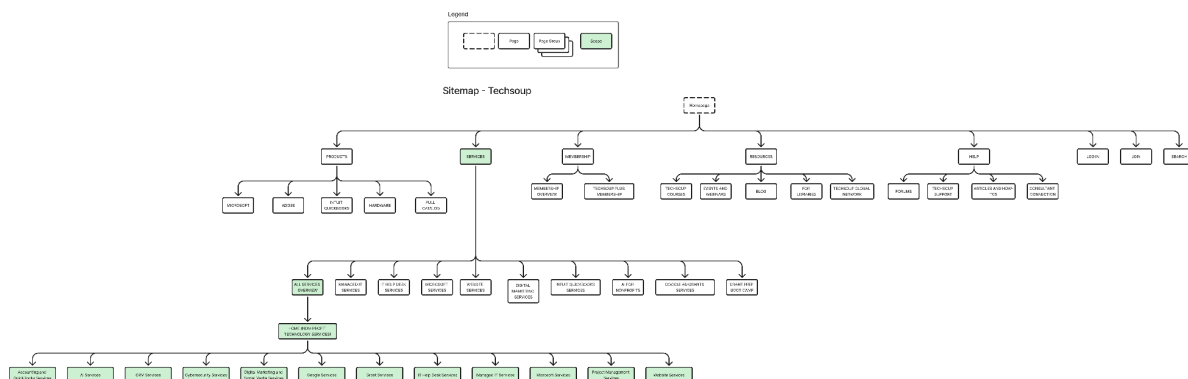
# Information Architecture Evaluation

An open card sorting study was conducted with two participants to understand how users naturally group and interpret TechSoup's content without predefined categories. Participants were given a set of cards representing services, products, and resources from the site and were asked to organize them into groups that made sense to them. This method was chosen to reveal unbiased mental models and identify gaps in the current information architecture.

Participants were generally able to group content correctly, indicating that the overall structure is somewhat intuitive. However, several items were confused due to unclear labeling or a lack of a clear category. While both participants showed similar grouping patterns, inconsistencies appeared around products, courses, and specialized services.

## USER FLOW

HOME → SERVICES → ALL SERVICES OVERVIEW → SELECT SERVICE



## General Findings

- Confusion on products services
- Confusion on learning-related content
- AI for nonprofits remained difficult to group

## Reflection

TechSoup has a clear mission and a clean site design. Its interface is professional and trustworthy, allowing users to feel safe when acquiring services for their organization. Here are the main takeaways:

- TechSoup has a clear mission, but first-time users may not immediately understand where to go or what step to take next.
- Accessibility issues should be treated as a major priority because low contrast and keyboard barriers can prevent some users from completing key actions.
- The biggest friction points happen early in the experience, especially around service discovery, membership validation, and choosing the right service.

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## NEXT STEPS

- Fixing accessibility problems to meet WCAG standards
- Membership validation moved later in the journey
- Further testing of first-time nonprofit users completing a request to a service